three-cornered balance, in which no party ruled out exploratory forays into others' territories.

Now, Fath and Hasan Khan had attacked some of Ali Quli's holdings; and even found a surviving Suri prince to proclaim king. Ali Quli and his men defeated the Afghans, and returned to Jaunpur, triumphant yet increasingly mistrusted, it seems, by the padishah. Only months after Ali Quli's victory, Akbar sent an envoy east, one Qilich Khan, who was to bypass Jaunpur's commander and negotiate directly with Fath Khan of Rohtas – the very man Ali Quli had just defeated.[31]

Not long after, another envoy left Akbar's court, heading east to yet another Uzbek's fief. This envoy was to meet Sikander Khan Uzbek, a fief-holder in Oudh, and encourage him to present himself in court, rumours of his 'brainless head . . . affected by seditiousness'[32] having preceded him there. Sikander made every show of respecting Akbar's messenger except actually obeying his instructions. Instead of going to Agra, he hurried to meet a neighbouring chieftain, an older Uzbek called Ibrahim Khan – who also happened to be Ali Quli's uncle – and both of them decamped to Ali Quli in Jaunpur. The padishah's messenger they put in chains.

The Uzbek rebellion had begun, and it would take no half measures. The whole soaring saga of it could fill a book of its own, and yet, such is the force of Akbar's historiography that even the names of the men who formed the first major resistance to his rule are largely forgotten.

At the time, however, Ali Quli and his brother Bahadur, their uncle Ibrahim and Sikander Khan Uzbek of Oudh were the most urgent talk of the court.

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The Uzbeks had cause to be upset with the padishah. Leaving aside the competing genealogies of Uzbek versus Chagatai, Timurid, or Moghul, these particular Uzbeks in Hindustan had every reason to believe that they had done more than enough to deserve pride of place in Akbar's court and realm. These men had been steadfast in their loyalty to Humayun through his battles with Kamran.[33] A modern historian tells of how, after a long march, Humayun once lay down with his head in Ali Quli's brother Bahadur's lap as Bahadur sang him to sleep.[34] When they crossed the Indus